doesn’t understand that we saved them from invasion; we saved them, but he doesn’t understand our policy,” said Khrushchev, referring to Castro. “You can’t explain it by letter, but it has to be explained, otherwise they won’t understand anything; someone has to go and explain it all properly.” Mikoyan remained silent. His wife, the sixty-five-year-old Ashkhen Mikoyan, was mortally ill. Khrushchev knew of her condition but said that one couldn’t help Ashken any longer. “You need to go,” he told his closest ally and critic. “Anastas, if the worst comes to pass, we’ll take care of everything—no need to worry.” As Mikoyan remembered the conversation a few months later, “He began saying that they know me there; I’ve been there and spoken with them; it would be easier for me to explain the situation to them and make the right arguments.” He eventually agreed: “I said that I was ready.”[2]

Khrushchev once said about Mikoyan’s diplomatic skills: “Not everyone understands what Mikoyan is saying when he talks, but he is a reasonable man.” Mikoyan, the “reasonable man,” became Khrushchev’s best bet to solve two Cuban crises in one—the first in relations between Moscow and Washington, and the second in relations between Moscow and Havana. He had to keep the Americans out of Cuba and the Soviets in, and the way to achieve that was by convincing Castro to accept UN inspection on his territory. For the Kremlin, the stakes were enormous. From Khrushchev’s perspective, he had saved Cuba from Kennedy by taking a huge risk but was about to lose it again, either to Kennedy or to Mao Zedong. The war that seemed to have been avoided could once again be on the doorsteps of Washington and Moscow, and Mikoyan was supposed to carry out what looked like mission impossible. By mid-October Cuba found itself in the middle of a new international crisis, bringing the possibility of nuclear war back into the picture.[3]

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KHRUSHCHEV PRESSED MIKOYAN TO GO TO CUBA ON THE evening of October 30. On the following night Mikoyan bade farewell to his dying wife and took a special Aeroflot flight to New York. If the commanders of the Soviet